

Advertisement

STARTUPS



**Anduril opens solid
rocket motor factory
amidst ongoing chemical
chokepoint**

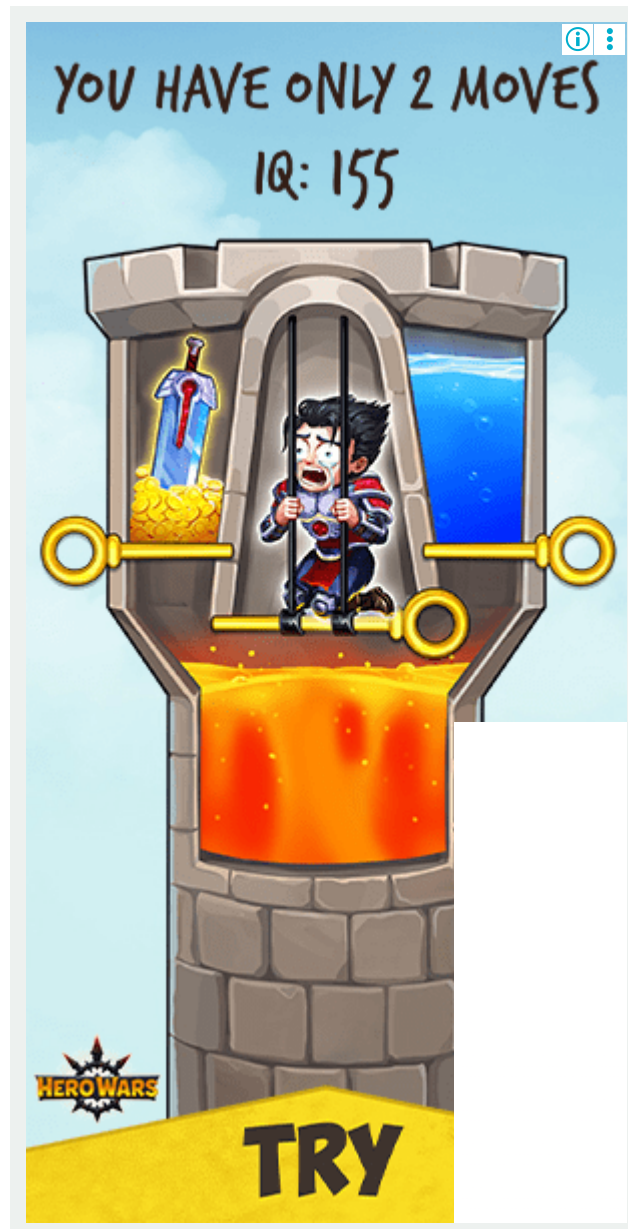
Anduril has officially brought its high-volume solid rocket motor (SRM) factory online in Mississippi as it races to fulfill America's demand for space and defense missions and challenge a decades-long duopoly between two major defense contractors.

The Mississippi factory will be able to produce 6,000 factory motors a year by the end of 2026, enough volume to position Anduril as the United States' "third" SRM supplier. More than 700 motors have already passed static test firing. These motors are used for a range of kinetic weapons, like missile interceptors, and even deep-space probes.

A handful of promising startups are pushing behind them as demand soars for weapons in the wake of the Russian invasion of Ukraine and mounting tensions in the South China Sea. The Defense Department has been keen to bolster American arsenals, awarding millions in funding to new entrants like Ursa Major and X-Bow Systems to take their products from prototype to commercialization.

As more SRM manufacturers come online, the vulnerability of another segment of the supply chain becomes even more apparent.

Every one of the motors these companies produce still needs ammonium perchlorate (AP), a powerful oxidizer that is made at scale by just one qualified producer: American Pacific, or AMPAC, in Utah.



DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

Northrop Grumman, a manufacturer of weapons that use SRMs, has invested more than \$100 million to establish an AP production line, but that production has been slow to scale due to the military's high standards for certification, [The Wall Street Journal reported](#) last year. Northrop did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment.

The AP supply chain is a chokepoint felt by suppliers, including Anduril. The risks remain the same, like accidents and fires that have the ability to destroy important assets, but the company believes the restoration of a second supplier is vital, and would welcome additional suppliers, according to the company.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

This is not a new issue, but as the SRM duopoly held by Northrop Grumman and L3Harris' Aerojet Rocketdyne is increasingly challenged by Anduril and others, it highlights a vulnerability in the supply chain.

Book Your Table >

Most Popular



- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach
- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue
- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request
- NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars
- Why I finally left Spotify

Jerry McGinn, a former senior industrial base official in the Department of Defense, said the need for multiple suppliers of AP dwindled as the demand for SRMs collapsed in the 1990s. The Pentagon backed a “merger-to-monopoly” in the 1990s, preferring to have one healthy provider rather than two struggling companies that couldn’t be competitive without government subsidies, he said.

Today’s single-source risk is less about capacity than about the demand signal resurgence, he argued. “Capacity is never the issue,” he said. “It’s just enough orders and lead time to create the fuel.”

AMPAC announced in April that its parent company would invest \$100 million in a new AP production line, which would increase capacity by 50%. The project is scheduled to be complete next year, a tight deadline even if everything goes to plan. AMPAC did not respond to TechCrunch’s request for comment on the status of that new line.

Balancing demand and lead time is delicate.

Pentagon acquisition chief Bill LaPlante called it “the tyranny of lead time” when speaking to lawmakers in February, warning against the “feast-or-famine” procurement behavior of times past.

“Industry also reasonably remains reluctant to build additional capacity “at risk” until they have a clear, consistent demand signal from DoD, often with specific procurement quantities for multiple years,” he said.

For its part, Ursa Major touted its additive manufacturing process to avoid the pitfalls that slow conventional manufacturing approaches, a spokesperson said. But even the most innovatively made motors will still need AP to burn.

Funding for SRM manufacturing is part of a larger push to fund the industrial base. To McGinn, if Washington can prototype the motors, it should be able to prototype AP, too.

“If developing a second source is imperative, then the government should focus on that by doing what they did with Ursa Major, X-Bow, and so on — by doing prototype efforts with other companies to develop another source of AP,” he said.

We’re always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we’re doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [anduril](#) [solid rocket motors](#) [Space](#) [Startups](#)



Aria Alamalhodaei

Reporter, Space and Defense | [X](#)

Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the public utilities...

[View Bio](#) >

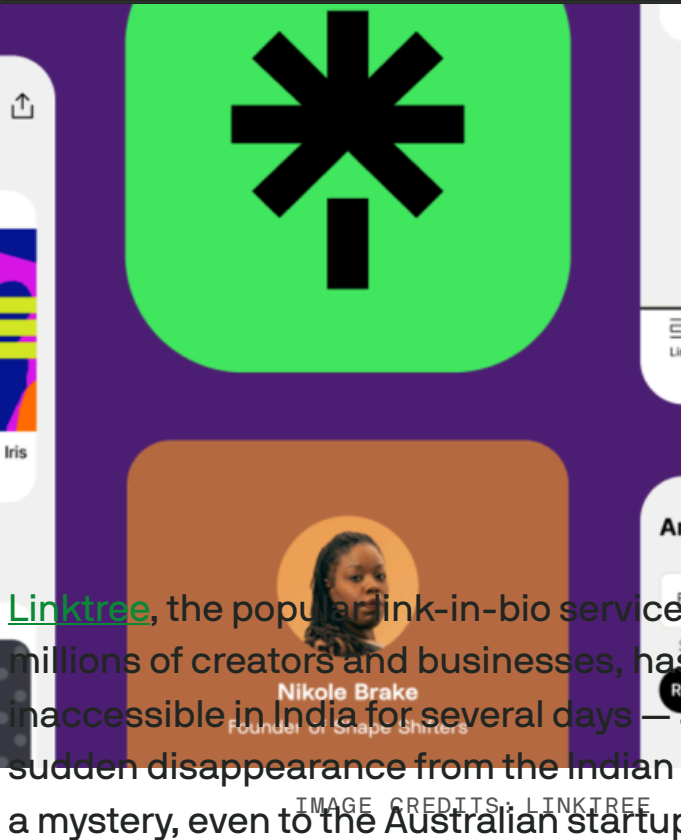
———— KEEP READING ————

Latest Security
Startups AI
Venture Apps
Apple

Events

Podcasts

Newsletters



[Linktree](#), the popular link-in-bio service used by millions of creators and businesses, has been inaccessible in India for several days — and its sudden disappearance from the Indian web remains a mystery, even to the Australian startup itself.

Over the past week, Linktree has been inaccessible in India, with a few users raising the issue on X. Initially, TechCrunch noticed that the site briefly displayed a message suggesting it had been blocked by the Indian government. Later, this was replaced by a generic SSL protocol error. The Linktree app has also been inaccessible in the country.

Founded in 2016, Linktree [became a unicorn in 2022](#) and [surpassed 50 million users](#) in 2024. India has been the platform's fifth-largest market by traffic, accounting for 3.5% of its global visits — or about 7.3 million in July, per Similarweb data shared with TechCrunch.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:46 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

Linktree's monthly visits in India
(in millions)

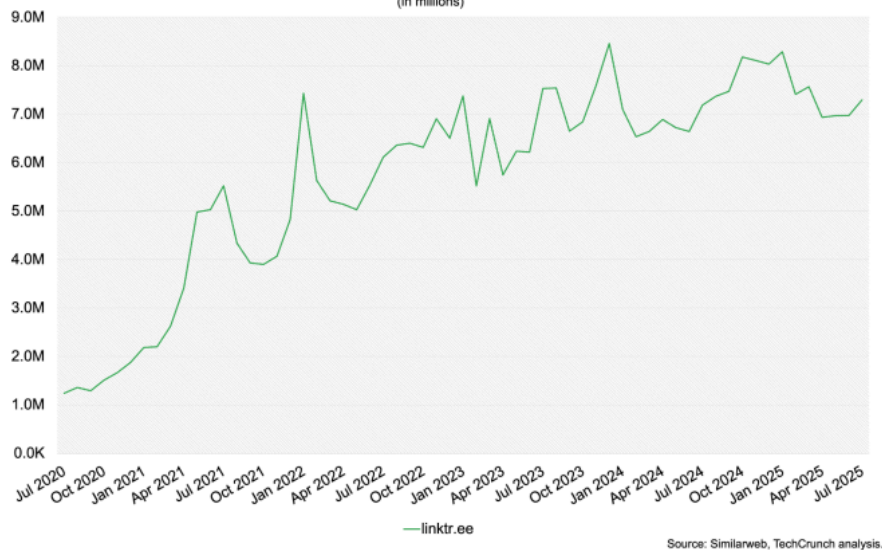


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Linktree co-founder and CEO Alex Zaccaria told TechCrunch that the startup was looking into the situation. However, the executive did not confirm whether the startup received a communication from Indian authorities on its blockage.

The startup later [posted](#) on X that it was aware of the service outage in India and was “investigating” the issue.

As [reported](#) by the Indian daily The Hindu, the outage is not limited to a specific internet service provider and appears to affect all major networks.

The U.S. remains Linktree’s top market, with 48.5 million visits, followed by Indonesia (32.3 million), Brazil (30.8 million), and the U.K. (9.4 million), Similarweb data shows.

India’s IT and telecom ministries did not respond to emails sent over the weekend.

We’re always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we’re doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).







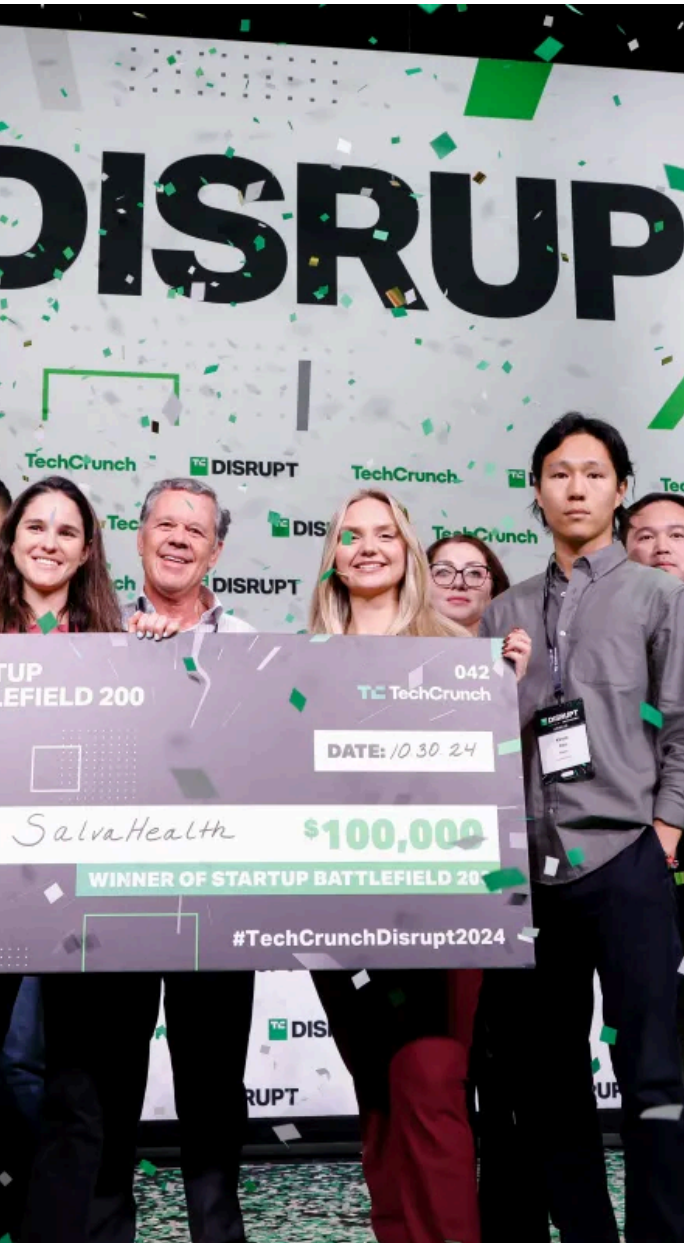
Jagmeet Singh

Reporter | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [Email](#) [LinkedIn](#)

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING



STARTUPS



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen — 9:22 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Set your alarms. Bookmark this page. Refresh like your future depends on it.

After reviewing thousands of groundbreaking applications from around the globe, TechCrunch is just days away from announcing the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 — our handpicked cohort of the most promising early-stage startups set to take the stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) this October 27-29.

The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list will go live, right here, on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT.

Whether you applied, referred a standout founder, or just want to see who made the cut, this is the moment you've been waiting for. Your name. Your rival. Your next investment. They might all be on this list.

This October marks 20 years that [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) has been shaping the startup world — and we're pulling out all the stops. For two decades, the biggest names in tech, venture capital, and startups have taken our stage to share their visions and make history. Game-changers like Dropbox, Cloudflare, Fitbit, and Discord got their start in [Startup Battlefield](#) — and this is where the next generation of breakout companies will be born.

Want to see these rising stars pitch live? Hear from top-tier founders and investors? Network with the people shaping the future of tech? [Grab your ticket to Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 in San Francisco.

Last year's winner, [Salva Health](#), topped a competitive field of startups with its development of a portable device to detect breast cancer early, especially in rural populations that lack access to mammograms and other diagnostic tools. You can relive their victory below, [listen to our Equity](#).

Latest in Startups

[See More](#)

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

STARTUPS



AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen
- 23 hours ago

[podcast interview with CEO Valentina Agudelo](#), or [get a detailed rundown of their journey here](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Announcing the winner of Startup Battlefield ...



Salva was far from alone. Out of the cohort of 200 trailblazing startups, TechCrunch editorial selected the [2024 Top 20 finalists](#) who wowed the crowd with their disruptive innovations, live demos, and perfected pitches. Runner-up [geCKo Materials](#) [turned heads with its compelling story](#) about how years of research led to a breakthrough innovation in adhesive materials that is disrupting the Velcro industry one impossibly sticky situation at a time.

This year's Startup Battlefield 200 Top 20 finalists will be revealed on Day 1 of Disrupt 2025 (Monday, October 27). You don't want to miss the chance to see these founders battle it out live onstage for the \$100,000 prize and Disrupt Cup. Your incumbent will be there. Your competitors have registered. Don't get left behind — [get your tickets to Disrupt 2025](#).

Mark your calendars and set your alarms — the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops right here on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT. Be the first to see which exceptional startups made the cut.

Startup Battlefield is proudly presented by Google Cloud, our premier sponsor.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [Gecko Materials](#) [Salva Health](#)

[Startup Battlefield](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#)

[TechCrunch Disrupt](#) [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#)

Isabelle Johannessen

Startup Battlefield Program Manager

Isabelle leads Startup Battlefield, TechCrunch’s iconic launchpad and competition for the world’s most promisin...

View Bio >

Loading the next article



- TechCrunch

Staff

Contact Us

Advertise

Crunchboard Jobs

Site Map
- Terms of Service

Privacy Policy

RSS Terms of Use
- Neuralink

Google Chrome

StubHub

Claude

GPT-5

Tech Layoffs

ChatGPT